

BEFORE

The Byzantine Empire grew out of the eastern Roman Empire, gradually acquiring a distinctive new Greek Christian culture that replaced the traditions of ancient Rome.

ANCIENT BYZANTIUM

According to legend, the Megaran king, **Byzas**, founded the Greek city of Byzantium in 667 BCE on the advice of the oracle at Delphi **◀94**.

FIRST DIVISION OF THE EMPIRE

In 293 CE the emperor **Diocletian** split the Roman Empire **◀110–13**, with two emperors (*Augusti*), one ruling in the east, the other in the west, assisted by two younger co-emperors (*Caesares*).

A NEW CAPITAL

When **Constantine** **◀148–49** defeated his last rival to become sole emperor in 324 CE, he decided to build a new capital, Nova Roma (New Rome), at Byzantium. Completed in 330 CE, it became known as **Constantinople** after his death.

FINAL DIVISION

In 395 CE the Roman Empire was definitively split into eastern and western divisions by Emperor **Theodosius**, the eastern empire being ruled from Constantinople. The last western emperor was deposed in 476 CE, but by then the true rulers in the west were the Goths, Vandals, Franks, and other Germanic peoples **◀188–89**.

BYZANTINE EMPRESS (500–48 CE)

THEODORA

Daughter of a circus bear-keeper, Theodora was a comic actress and, some claim, a prostitute, before marrying Justinian in 523. When he became emperor of Byzantium in 527, Theodora proved herself a talented ruler in her own right. Her advice quelled the Nika riots of 532, probably saving the empire. She is regarded as an advocate for women's rights who used her position to help her society's oppressed, and she is venerated as a saint in the Orthodox church.



The term “Byzantine Empire” suggests a separate entity from the Roman Empire. The Byzantines, however, called themselves Romans and their realm Romania. Constantinople had been the capital of the Roman Empire since the reign of Constantine (306–37 CE), and the center of gravity of Mediterranean civilization had shifted to its eastern shores long before the final collapse

Hagia Sophia

Built by Justinian I in five years (532–37), the Hagia Sophia church (meaning “holy wisdom”) was converted into a mosque in 1453 by the Ottomans. Despite later additions, it remains one of the finest examples of Byzantine church architecture.



The Byzantine Empire

A great metropolis when the capitals of Western Europe were little more than villages, Constantinople stood for more than a millennium at the heart of its empire, a center of religion and culture, and a military power forming a protective barrier that allowed Europe to emerge from the ruins of the Roman Empire.

of Rome. The city stood at a strategic position that controlled the trade routes between Asia and Europe, as well as the passage from the Black Sea to the Mediterranean.

When the German Odoacer deposed the last western emperor, Romulus Augustulus, in 476 CE, the Byzantine emperor Zeno became sole heir to the Roman Empire. One of his most significant acts was to persuade the Ostrogothic leader Theodoric, who was threatening to do in the east what other barbarian tribes had done in the west, to conquer Italy rather than take part of the eastern empire.

Conquests and losses

The first emperor to attempt to regain lost territories in the west was Justinian, who reigned from 527–65. His armies won back North Africa from the Vandals and also reconquered much of Italy. In addition to these conquests, Justinian left a substantial cultural legacy in the form of magnificent churches and a thorough codification of Roman law.

In the east, however, things did not run so smoothly. The Persian Sassanids (see pp.122–23) broke a treaty made



Rare Byzantine relic

A survivor of the sack of Constantinople in 1204, this gilt enamel reliquary is said to contain a fragment of the cross on which Jesus Christ was crucified.

with Justinian and entered imperial territory in 540, seizing the city of Antioch. There followed an exhausting series of military clashes until the emperor Heraclius won a decisive victory over the Persians in 628. No sooner had he won control of the east, however, than the Muslim Arabs (see pp.174–77) invaded, and the empire lost its eastern provinces to Islam. Constantinople was besieged for four years in 674–78. It survived thanks to the secret weapon Greek fire, a flammable liquid used as a flamethrower, whose composition remains

a mystery to this day.

The empire faced many enemies besides the Arabs, including the Lombards in Italy and the Bulgars in the Balkan peninsula, but somehow Byzantium survived. Heraclius introduced a system of government, in which the empire was divided into military provinces, called “themes,” each governed by an independent *strategos* or general.

Orthodoxy

Despite the chronic instability of its empire and periodic outbreaks of plague, the city of Constantinople

The Mosaic of the Donors

Located above the imperial bodyguard's Vestibule of the Warriors, which today serves as the exit, the Mosaic of the Donors illustrates the consecration of the Hagia Sophia, its dedication to Christ, and Constantinople's status as capital of a Christian empire.

The emperor Justinian

offers the Church of Holy Wisdom (the Hagia Sophia) to the Virgin Mary and the baby Jesus.

